Getting there: Three hours' drive from Jodhpur airport, 2 hr 45 mins from Udaipur airport, 20-minute drive from Jawai Band railway station

Resort rooms: Lake-view rooms, chalets with private gardens, chalet with private heated pool, and Khema tents. The most popular package is room with breakfast, high tea, dinner, and one safari per day (winter price ranges from Rs 28,000 to Rs 75,000 plus taxes per room per night, depending on the room category)

Special dining: Signature Dining in the wilderness with chef and butler (starts from Rs 5,000 plus taxes per person and can go up to Rs 10,000 plus taxes per person). Jawai Under the Sky operates only in the evening for wood-fired pizza, barbecue and some special pastas (cover charge of Rs 3,000 plus taxes, redeemable against food and liquor).

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flowers whose leaves he says are used for mehndi, and bark in shoe polish. Near Kothar village, we drive past an Indian thick-knee bird, hear a laughing dove, glimpse a Brahminy starling. We stop to help a soft-shell turtle off the road, and watch cattle egrets picking off insects kicked up by cows' hooves. No luck with Neelam, so we try Lilorah village, the territory of Jia, a nine-year-old female with three cubs. We wait at the foot of a massive hill while flocks of goats and sheep are herded home a few feet away by red-turbaned Rabari shepherds.

There isn't much wild prey in Jawai—no deer, just a few nilgai, monkeys, peacocks and other birds, wild boar, porcupines, small wild cats. But